

ISTQB FOUNDATION MASTERCLASS

Quick Revision Notes

High-yield facts for every ISTQB Foundation syllabus chapter.

Introduction

This is your last-minute revision sheet: the highest-yield facts from each chapter of the ISTQB Foundation syllabus, condensed for a final read-through before the exam.

Ch.1 — Fundamentals of Testing

- Testing evaluates quality and reduces the risk of failure in operation.
- Testing is not just execution — it includes planning, analysis, design and reporting.
- Error → defect → failure. A failure can also come from environmental conditions.
- Testing shows the presence of defects, not their absence.
- Verification = building it right; validation = building the right thing.

The Seven Testing Principles

1. Testing shows the presence of defects, not their absence.
2. Exhaustive testing is impossible — use risk and priorities instead.
3. Early testing saves time and money (shift left).
4. Defects cluster together — a few modules hold most defects.
5. Beware the pesticide paradox — repeating the same tests stops finding new defects; vary them.
6. Testing is context dependent — you test differently in different contexts.
7. Absence-of-errors is a fallacy — a defect-free system can still be unusable or wrong.

Ch.2 — Testing Throughout the SDLC

Good testing fits the development model, has a matching test level for every development level, and starts as early as possible (shift-left).

Test Levels

Level	Focus
Component (unit)	Individual components in isolation
Integration	Interfaces and interactions between components/systems
System	The behaviour of the whole system end to end
Acceptance	Readiness for use / fitness for purpose (UAT, operational, contractual/regulatory, alpha, beta)

Test Types

Type	Answers
Functional	What the system does
Non-functional	How well it behaves (performance, usability, security, reliability, portability)
White-box (structural)	How much of the structure is exercised
Change-related	Confirmation testing (retest) and regression testing after changes

Maintenance Testing

Triggered by modifications, migration or retirement. Impact analysis decides what to regression test.

Ch.3 — Static Testing

- Static testing examines work products without executing code.
- Two forms: reviews (human) and static analysis (tool-based).
- Finds defects early and cheaply — even in requirements before code exists.
- Review types by formality: informal, walkthrough, technical review, inspection.
- Roles: author, manager, facilitator, review leader, reviewer, scribe.

Ch.4 — Test Techniques

Category	Techniques
Black-box	Equivalence partitioning, boundary value analysis, decision tables, state transition
White-box	Statement coverage, branch/decision coverage
Experience-based	Error guessing, exploratory testing, checklist-based testing

- EP: divide inputs into groups treated the same; test one value per partition.
- BVA: test at the edges of partitions where defects cluster.
- Decision tables: cover combinations of conditions and actions.
- State transition: cover valid (and sometimes invalid) transitions between states.
- Statement coverage < branch coverage in thoroughness (100% branch implies 100% statement).

Ch.5 — Test Management

- Test plan documents objectives, scope, approach, resources and schedule.
- Entry criteria start an activity; exit criteria complete it.
- Risk level = likelihood × impact; risk-based testing prioritises effort.
- Product risk = the product may be faulty; project risk = management/schedule/resource issues.
- Monitoring measures progress; control acts to meet the plan.
- Reports: interim (progress) and summary (completion).

Ch.6 — Tool Support for Testing

- Tools support activities across the whole test process (management, static, design, execution, performance).
- Benefits: reduced repetitive work, greater consistency, objective measurement, easier access to information.
- Risks: unrealistic expectations, underestimating effort to introduce, over-reliance, poor maintenance of the tool/scripts.
- Run a proof of concept and a pilot before rolling a tool out organisation-wide.

Final Exam Tips

- Read every question fully — watch for "NOT" and "BEST/MOST".
- Eliminate obviously wrong answers first.
- Trust the precise ISTQB definition over everyday usage.
- Manage your time — do not linger on one question.

Common Mistakes

- Mixing up the seven principles.
- Confusing test levels (what is tested) with test types (why/how).
- Assuming 100% statement coverage means 100% branch coverage — it does not.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

If you can recite the seven principles, the four test levels, and the risk formula from memory, you have already secured a large share of the exam marks. Drill those three lists until they are effortless.